

electricity, water jets and even diamonds to achieve extremely accurate shapes and designs. Although these used to be strictly industrial, the maker movement has seen the rise of community funded machine workshops which are often open to all.

- ♦ **Open Source Programming** – If electronics is the brain of Maker tech, this is what makes those grey cells tick. With vast repositories of open source code available to program most popular systems for virtually anything, you no longer need to be a computer wizard to make your system work. In many cases, even understanding ‘hello world’ will do.
- ♦ **Reference Designs** – A major part of maker tech is using the 3D printers and CNC tools to fabricate a product. If you do not possess the artistic hand of a virtuoso, you are not alone. There are millions of designs and standard blueprints available online that you can use in your process with minor or sometimes no changes.

Of Bytes and Prototypes – What differentiates Maker Tech from Hacker Tech?

Before we begin this comparison, it needs to be cleared that hackers, the ones that form the hacker culture that has been around since the 60's, are not always evil anti-system programming geniuses looking to exploit the next weakness in computer security. The term is also used to refer to the people who modify existing software or hardware to make new things or to suit their needs. Now that we have that cleared up, let us understand what Hacker culture and Hacker tech really denotes.

Broadly, hacking is doing something to overcome the limitations of a system or its traditional usage. Over time, the term has mostly become centred on programming. A hacker is someone whose objective is to explore beyond the evident possibilities of programming with playful cleverness mingled with excellence.

One of the major principles of the hacker culture has been free information. Hackers believe that every person in the world should have equal and unrestricted access to all the information in the world. It is quite obvious that Hacking, as we generally see it, is only concerned with software and programming. So as a consequence, when we talk about Hacker tech we refer to Free and Open Source Software used by hackers and programmers to implement novel ideas digitally on a virtual platform.

Maker tech includes, but is not limited to, programming. To be appropriately perceived, Maker tech can be seen as an intersecting region between